July 26: Activist T.J. Abraham petitions Governor Thaawar Chand Gehlot, seeking sanction for prosecution of CM under the Prevention of Corruption Act for receiving MUDA sites; two more persons file complaints subsequently

Aug. 16: Governor accords sanction to investigate allegations

Sept. 24: Karnataka High Court upholds governor's order

G. Parameshwara, H.C. Mahadevappa and Satish Jarkiholi. The latter's visits to Delhi especially evoked much interest. A Siddaramaiah loyalist, Jarkiholi is a powerful leader from the ST community. Therefore, his meetings with Parameshwara and Mahadevappa, both prominent SC leaders, fuelled speculation that the call for Karnataka to get its first ever Dalit or Adivasi CM may be renewed were a leadership change to take place. It's a gap that has been recurrently highlighted in the state's political discourse. It also suggested that there could likely be contenders from the Siddaramaiah camp jockeying with deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar who is currently No. 2 in the Congress government. However, a senior party leader, while pointing out that Siddaramaiah remains by far the most popular Congress leader in Karnataka, says these are matters to be dealt with in the longer term.

More immediately, however, the ruling party has to gear up for the November 13 bypolls that will fill up the vacancies created after former CMs Kumaraswamy and Basavaraj Bommai, and MLA E. Tukaram, were elected as Lok Sabha members. Of the three bypolls, the Channapatna seat is where a high-stakes battle for dominance of the Vokkaliga community is brewing between Kumaraswamy—who vacated the seat—and his bete noire Shivakumar. ■



PTI

LAYING THE AGENDA RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat delivering his Vijayadashami address, Oct. 12

RSS-BJP

Banking on Hindutva Again

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

The Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat's ceremonial Vijayadashami speech this year featured an impassioned plea for Hindu unification, coming with a stark warning: weakness is a sin that even the gods disdain. The spectre of violence against Bangladeshi Hindus earlier this year served as his grim exemplar, a cautionary tale of what befalls a weakened community. Just a week earlier, as if in sync, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, speaking at a Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) rally in poll-bound Maharashtra, launched a scathing attack on the Congress, accusing the Opposition party of playing divisive politics. "Congress knows that the more Hindus get divided, the more it will benefit," he declared.

This duet, performed by the two titans of the Sangh Parivar, perhaps appends a coda to a symphony of whispers that had picked up lately. A rumoured rift between the two had been the season's flavour, especially after reports of RSS swayamsevaks largely keeping away from the BJP's campaign during the Lok Sabha polls earlier this year. Their harmonised message now reveals a shared playbook. And as India finds itself in the throes of poll fever yet again, with the Election Commission announcing dates for Maharashtra and Jharkhand as well as a smattering of byelections next month, the BJP is betting big on this revitalised narrative.

The recent Haryana assembly results have injected a shot of euphoria into the BJP ranks. The party's historic hat-trick in the